

In France, the feminization of Boards of Directors and Supervisory Boards is advancing quickly, while progress on Executive Committees is stagnating.

Is this truly surprising? What should we conclude?

Many statistical studies conducted in recent years note that in France — particularly due to the January 2011 law — the share of women on Boards of Directors and Supervisory Boards has risen rapidly, whereas the proportion on Executive Committees (or Management Committees) has stalled. Can this be explained?

We may regret it, but objectively, we should not be surprised.

The explanation is fairly simple and points to a way forward.

At least in France, the role and selection process for members of an executive committee (Comex) are very different from those for directors serving on a board.

For the professional recruitment of directors, companies look for diversity of profiles, notably based on independence criteria. As a result, directors are generally sought outside the company's top management. That said, there is the particular case of the Chair and CEO (and the CEO if they are also a director, which is relatively rare).

The pool of potential candidates for board seats is therefore broad, since candidates may bring professional experience from various sectors and from companies other than the one to which they are applying.

By contrast, when recruiting executives who will sit on the Comex, the search focuses on candidates capable of leading operating units or functions full-time — a role quite different from that of a director. The candidate must know the company's domain very well and bring clear added value. The pool of potential external candidates — particularly women — is significantly smaller.

Consequently, for Comex roles, it is much less common to bring in an external figure, and when it does happen, it is often because no one internally can be a strong short-term candidate (for example, following the resignation of the CFO).

Recruiting external women with the express goal of increasing female representation will certainly be necessary in some circumstances. However, it can also demotivate internal male candidates who would "naturally" aspire to such roles; they may perceive these hires as driven by gender rather than merit — an issue that arises far less often for boards.

In general, those appointed to the Comex are chosen from among the company's senior leaders. Yet, because the glass ceiling still exists, the pool of potential female candidates is often small. Even with goodwill and the support of convinced female directors, recruiting women to the Comex will therefore remain difficult in the coming years.

Indeed, before making Comex appointments, companies need first to advance high-potential women to the level just below the Comex and ensure they have operational experience beyond HR and Communications.

Such a company-wide objective cannot be dictated by law. At best, the law can require companies to set and disclose their goals. This approach, incidentally, appears in the draft European Directive led by Ms. Reding.

In conclusion, comparisons between the pace of feminization on Comex and that on boards should be handled with care.